Rain Compilation

By Mary Oliver, Delmore Schwartz, Amy Lowell and Sara Teasdale

INTRODUCTION

In this poetry compilation the theme of rain, in all its many forms, is presented by various poets: Mary Oliver, Delmore Schwarts, Amy Lowel and Sara Teasdale. The descriptions and feelings evoked by nature's simple act of rain are both universal and timeless.

Last Night the Rain Spoke to Me
by Mary Oliver

Last night
the rain
spoke to me
slowly, saying,

what joy
to come falling
out of the brisk cloud,
to be happy again

in a new way
on the earth!

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That's what it said
as it dropped,

smelling of iron,
and vanished
like a dream of the ocean
into the branches

and the grass below.
Then it was over.
The sky cleared.
I was standing

under a tree.
The tree was a tree
with happy leaves,
and I was myself,

and there were stars in the sky
that were also themselves
at the moment
at which moment

my right hand
was holding my left hand
which was holding the tree
which was filled with stars

and the soft rain—
imagine! imagine!

the long and wondrous journeys
still to be ours.

And
Rain

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Mary Oliver
Book: New Selected Poems Volume 1
ISBN: 978-0807068199
Publisher: Beacon Press
Date (Month/Year): July 1993

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

TRANSITION

The older I get, the more I enjoy the rain: the sound of it, the scent of it, the look of it. When I was a young kid, rain was a game changer. It almost always ruined my plans for fun.
Now I can sit at a window with a good book and stare out at rainy days with a thankful heart.

The First Night of Fall and Falling Rain by Delmore Schwartz

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The common rain had come again
Slanting and colorless, pale and anonymous,
Fainting falling in the first evening
Of the first perception of the actual fall,
The long and late light had slowly gathered up
A sooty wood of clouded sky, dim and distant more and more
Until, at dusk, the very sense of selfhood waned,
A weakening nothing halted, diminished or denied or set aside,
Neither tea, nor, after an hour, whiskey,
Ice and then a pleasant glow, a burning,
And the first leaping wood fire
Since a cold night in May, too long ago to be more than
Merely a cold and vivid memory.
Staring, empty, and without thought
Beyond the rising mists of the emotion of causeless sadness,
How suddenly all consciousness leaped in spontaneous gladness,
Knowing without thinking how the falling rain (outside, all

over)

In slow sustained consistent vibration all over outside

Tapping window, streaking roof,

running down runnel and drain

Waking a sense, once more, of all that lived outside of us,

Beyond emotion, for beyond the swollen

distorted shadows and lights

Of the toy town and the vanity fair

of waking consciousness!

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Delmore Schwartz
Book: Last and Lost Poems
ISBN: 978-0811210966
Publisher: New Directions Publishing
Date (Month/Year): 1989

TRANSITION

Those few minutes after it stops raining–when the sun shows it's face through the clouds–those minutes are my favorite. It's so easy to feel at peace when the world around you is dripping wet, totally refreshed and reflecting the warm sun-glow.

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Afternoon Rain in State Street by Amy Lowell

Cross-hatchings of rain against grey walls,

Slant lines of black rain

In front of the up and down, wet stone sides of buildings.

Below,

Greasy, shiny, black, horizontal,

The street.

And over it, umbrellas,

Black polished dots

Struck to white

An instant,

Stream in two flat lines

Slipping past each other with the smoothness of oil.

Like a four-sided wedge

The Custom House Tower

Pokes at the low, flat sky,

Pushing it farther and farther up,

Lifting it away from the house-tops,

Lifting it in one piece as though it were a sheet of tin,

With the lever of its apex.
The cross-hatchings of rain cut the Tower obliquely,
Scratching lines of black wire across it,
Mutilating its perpendicular grey surface
With the sharp precision of tools.
The city is rigid with straight lines and angles,
A chequered table of blacks and greys.
Oblong blocks of flatness
Crawl by with low-geared engines,
And pass to short upright squares
Shrinking with distance.
A steamer in the basin blows its whistle,
And the sound shoots across the rain hatchings,
A narrow, level bar of steel.
Hard cubes of lemon
Superimpose themselves upon the fronts of buildings
As the windows light up.
But the lemon cubes are edged with angles
Upon which they cannot impinge.
Up, straight, down, straight -- square.
Crumpled grey-white papers

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Blow along the side-walks,
Contorted, horrible,
Without curves.
A horse steps in a puddle,
And white, glaring water spurts up
In stiff, outflaring lines,
Like the rattling stems of reeds.
The city is heraldic with angles,
A sombre escutcheon of argent and sable
And countercoloured bends of rain
Hung over a four-square civilization.
When a street lamp comes out,
I gaze at it for fully thirty seconds
To rest my brain with the suffusing, round brilliance of its globe.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Amy Lowell
Book: Amy Lowell Remembered by Jean Elizabeth Ward
ISBN: 978-1435732469
Publisher: Lulu.com
Date (Month/Year): 2009

TRANSITION

What would happen if humans disappeared from the earth? What would the world be like without us? How would nature respond? For Sara Teasdale, the answer is "There will Come Soft Rains"

There Will Come Soft Rains
By Sara Teasdale

There will come soft rains and the smell of the ground,
And swallows circling with their shimmering sound;

And frogs in the pools singing at night,
And wild plum trees in tremulous white,

Robins will wear their feathery fire
Whistling their whims on a low fence-wire;

And not one will know of the war, not one
Will care at last when it is done.

Not one would mind, neither bird nor tree
If mankind perished utterly;

And Spring herself, when she woke at dawn,
Would scarcely know that we were gone.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sara Teasdale
Book: The Essential Sara Teasdale Poetry Collection
ISBN: 978-1449973353
Publisher: CreateSpace Independent Publishing Platform
Date (Month/Year): Dec 2009

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